

MALLS

Not Well

It was the future everybody wanted a slice of. Ten years after the first mall opened in Mumbai, the shine is fading.

By Malini Bhupta with Nandini Vaish |

There was a time when India's first mall, Crossroads Mumbai, found it difficult to manage customer traffic. In order to restrict footfalls, the mall decided to allow entry to those who had either a credit card or a mobile phone. A lot has changed in the last 10 years: malls are now being abandoned by retailers and consumers alike. Perceived to be the ultimate money churner, anyone with a piece of land decided to enter the retail business with a mall. Indeed, 2008 saw 9.6 million sq ft of mall space coming up all over the country, an 18 per cent increase over 2007. The deluge was followed by a slowdown and mall mania turned into mall trauma. The tide has truly turned for developers and retailers, who had blindly jumped into the mall business without understanding the demographics and demand. Now these glitzy temples of consumption wear a deserted look, with retailers and consumers checking out. From Gurgaon to Ahmedabad, consumers are walking out of malls that don't cater to their needs.

Last month, UK fashion retailer Debenhams walked out of DLF Place in Saket, Delhi, while Indiabulls Mega-store and Magnet Hypermarket signed out of Dev Arc Mall in Ahmedabad. Explains Amanpreet Banga, commercial manager

**MOUNTING
LOSSES AND
MISSING
FOOTFALLS
MAKE FOR A
FALTERING
MALL STORY**

